details, as the guidelines mandated), which created problems while resolving concerns on ending duplication.[127] Other critics have described the problems that women face when it comes to refilling the LPG cylinders. While these are valid concerns, the fact is that, on women, Modi and the BJP have a story to tell. Whatever the flaws in their story, its broad contours have been convincing enough for large numbers of women to switch to the party as never before, especially in the Hindi heartland states. Consider how Modi sells the Ujjwala story in his public outreach. In a speech to the Indian Merchants' Chamber Ladies' Wing in April 2017, he said:[128]

Mothers and sisters can imagine that when a wood stove is burnt, when a mother makes food by burning a wood stove, her body ingests smoke equal to that from 400 cigarettes a day. When children play in the house, imagine what would be happening to them with the smoke? What would be happening to their bodies? Understanding this pain and problem, I initiated a campaign to save these mothers and sisters from wooden stoves … we took up the big challenge to save these families from smoke … The law, rules and schemes are one thing, but in day-to-day life, change happens when they are implemented, [when] facilities reach the person sitting at the last end [of the process]. This government's identity is that when schemes are made, roadmaps are made, and to fulfil them, continuous monitoring is done.

Politically, it may not matter to voters if such schemes have some leakages, as long as they are seen to be working by and large. Like Swachh Bharat, their importance lies as much in the symbolism as in the final delivery. They were central to the Modi government's primary political messaging: that its achievements on women-focused welfare were better than those of governments that came before.

The BJP, the RSS and Questions of Gender

Vijaya Raje Scindia, the original BJP woman torchbearer, created a furore in 1990 when she defended 'voluntary sati' in Parliament. She